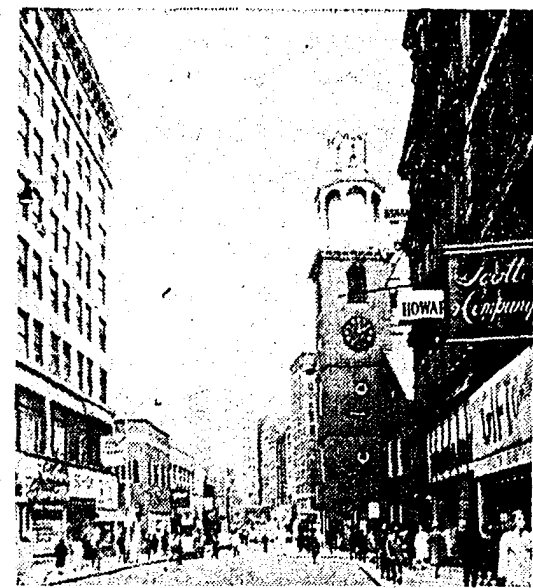


Washington street mall needed more than ever: ARCHITECTURE

Campbell, Robert

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WASHINGTON STREET . . . as it appears nowadays

Washington street mall needed more than ever

Will Boston ever have a pedestrian shopping mall downtown — a quiet place to walk and shop, free from the noise and filth of automobiles?

Not long ago it seemed we would. The Washington Street Pedestrian Mall, announced with great fanfare in the waning days of the Collins administration, was a sweeping plan to close most of Washington Street to all vehicles and turn it into a pedestrian haven, decked out with new trees, benches, lights and flags.

It was to be a place for strolling, for concerts, art shows and outdoor cafes.

ARCHITECTURE/By ROBERT CAMPBELL

Crossing this new Washington Mall, another mall was to run from the Common to South Station along Winter and Summer streets. Scheduled to be completed by 1975, the scheme meant taking the whole center of Boston away from the automobile and giving it to the pedestrian.

What happened? Well, the plan, designed by Victor Gruen and Associates, is still on the books and is still official city policy approved by the City Council and two mayors, but it isn't likely that it will ever be implemented.

No sooner was the plan

announced than the Federal government, whose financial aid was needed to build service streets and tunnels that traffic planners said were needed to make the Mall idea work, shifted its renewal dollars out of the downtown business areas and into low-income housing instead. A few months after its launching, the Washington Mall sank.

While Boston's Mall foundered, other cities were moving ahead. Pedestrians took over the streets of Copenhagen, Munich, Ottawa. In car-crazy Italy, the city of Florence closed 40 blocks. In Germany no fewer than 28 cities since 1967 have created pedestrian downtown zones.

Fresno, Minneapolis, Providence, Santa Cruz and other cities in this country have established

successful malls, and in July New York plans to close 15 blocks of Madison Avenue. Often opposed at first by businessmen, these malls almost invariably turned out to be good for business and frequently stimulated new development.

With these examples for encouragement, Boston shouldn't let its Mall die. The truth is that Washington street simply isn't going to survive if it remains in its present state. With people overflowing from jammed eight-foot sidewalks into a street already so narrow that a single parked truck can reduce it to one useful lane, it's clear that Washington street can't go on forever trying to serve both cars and people. And the climate of opinion seems to be shifting in favor of pedestrians.

Some encouraging signs:

—Pollution, gas shortage and growing traffic jams have awakened many people to the drawbacks of the private automobile. Governor Sargent's veto on highway construction is an example.

—The need to "improve traffic flow" is no longer regarded as sacred in planning circles. Designers have come to realize that wide, straight, uninterrupted streets merely draw more cars into the city, and at the same time destroy the spatial variety and human scale of Boston's narrow, twisting downtown thoroughfares, which were designed for

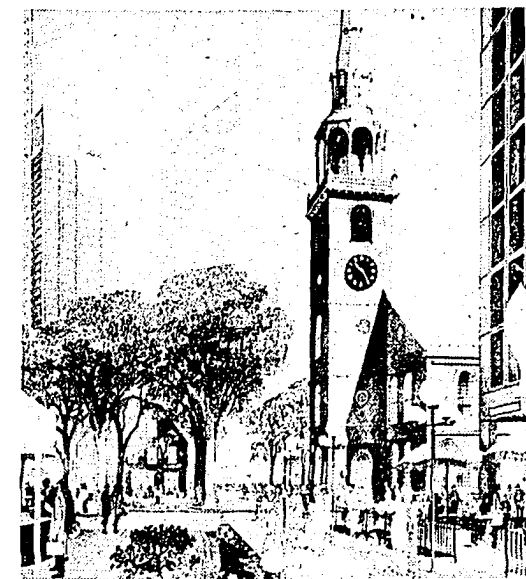
people and cows, not cars, in the first place.

—The financial success of malls in other cities has allayed many of the fears of retailers.

—Finally, the burgeoning suburban malls like Burlington and Shopper's World have accustomed shoppers to the pleasures and convenience of car-free shopping. They are starting to look for the same qualities downtown.

Even if Boston can't have the big, grandiose Mall that Gruen and the BRA originally proposed

there are still ways to tilt the balance in favor of the pedestrian. A start has already been made at the corners of School and Franklin, where street realignments have eased the traffic chaos and created small parks financed by local businesses. A third small park is planned at Essex street. The next logical step, now being studied by BRA planners, would be to widen sidewalks, ban private cars and restrict vehicles to a service lane, as is done in Minneapolis.



. . . and Washington street as it could be.